

Social Exchange Theory: Why People Respond

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Social Exchange Theory (Homans, 1961; Blau, 1964; Dillman, 1978)

- People are more likely to comply with a request from someone else if they believe and **trust** that the **rewards** for complying with that request will eventually exceed the **costs** of complying (Dillman, et al., 2014)



Social Exchange Theory

- The exchange in survey research is information provided by the respondent to the researcher as the researcher provides the respondent with the opportunity
 - (1) to personally and visibly promote the social good,
 - (2) to be recognized and included,
 - (3) to express an opinion that will be valued and counted,
 - (4) to learn about a topic,
 - (5) to reflect on and come to decisions about aspects of a topic, and
 - (6) to satisfy his or her curiosity.



Social Exchange Theory - Rewards

- Specify How the Survey Results Will Be Useful
 - Is it possible or likely that survey results will influence a community or organization decision?
 - Is public policy a likely beneficiary?
- Ask for Help or Advice
 - This may help your respondents' understand that they are uniquely able to answer the questions and feel like they are contributing to something. For many people, this is a reward.



Social Exchange Theory - Rewards

- Ask Interesting Questions
 - When questions are interesting, and it can be explained in communications that the questionnaire will be interesting, people are more likely to feel they benefit from answering them.
- Use Cash and Material Incentives to Encourage (but Not Require) Reciprocity
 - prepaid monetary incentives are the best



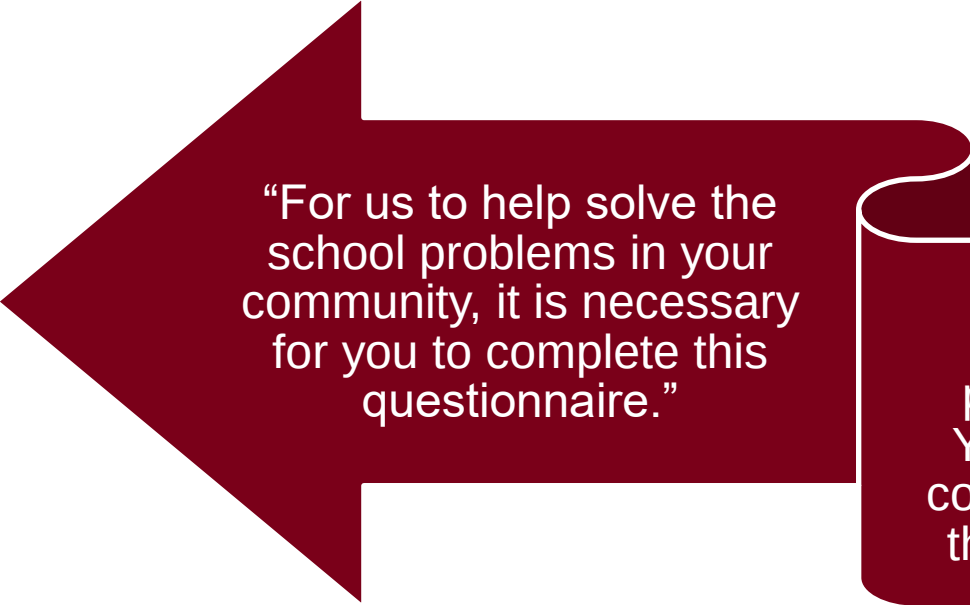
Social Exchange Theory - Costs

- Reduce the Burden of Length and Complexity
 - Only collect information that you know you will analyze
 - Have a data analysis plan in advance
- Use Visual Design Principles to Make Questionnaires Easier to Complete
- Make It Convenient to Respond
 - In mail surveys, this involves sending a business reply or stamped return envelope
 - In internet surveys, send email with link

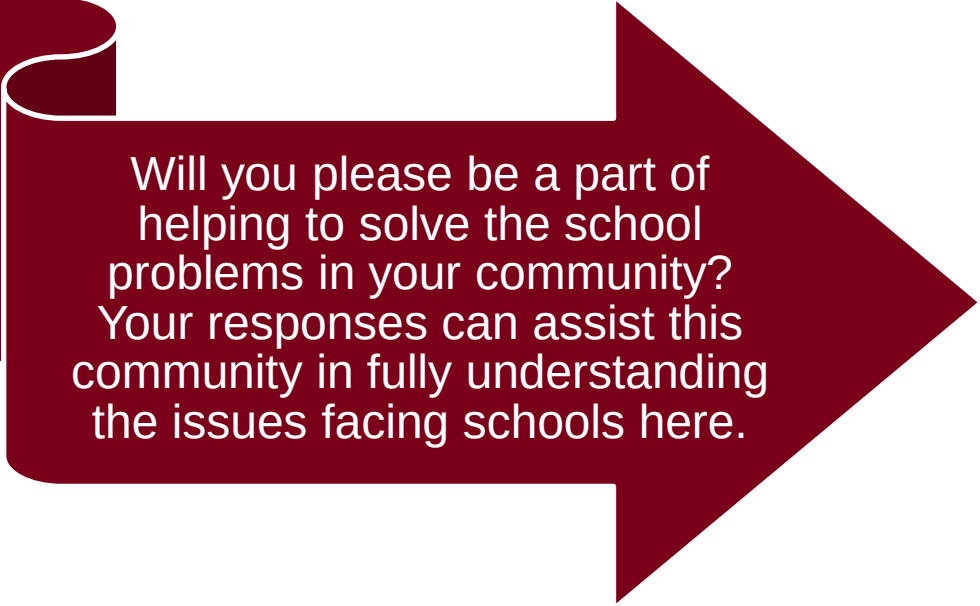


Social Exchange Theory - Costs

- Avoid Subordinating Language



“For us to help solve the school problems in your community, it is necessary for you to complete this questionnaire.”



Will you please be a part of helping to solve the school problems in your community? Your responses can assist this community in fully understanding the issues facing schools here.



Social Exchange Theory - Costs

- Recognize That Offering a Choice of Response Modes May Lower Response Rates
- Minimize Requests to Obtain Personal or Sensitive Information
- If sensitive information is needed, one should
 - ask the questions in a self-administered mode that provides more privacy for responding
 - ask them later in the survey to allow time for trust and rapport to develop
 - provide simple explanations for why responses to these questions are important and how the information will be protected



Social Exchange Theory - Trust

- Emphasize Sponsorship by a Legitimate Authority
 - Government agency
 - University
- Assure Confidentiality and Protection of Data
 - Explain the efforts that will be taken to ensure the confidentiality and security of people's survey responses
 - Be careful not to overdo it



Social Exchange Theory - Trust

- Provide Ways for Sample Members to Assess the Authenticity of a Survey Request and Ask Questions About It
 - providing a physical address where the sponsor is located
 - listing a toll-free number that sample members can call to talk to a real person
 - include a web address where sample members can find additional information about the sponsor, background on the survey, and even results from previous surveys
 - a specific e-mail address for asking questions should be made available





Decrease Costs

- Reduce length and complexity
- Use good visual design
- Avoid subordinating people
- Make responding convenient
- Avoid uncomfortable modes
- Avoid offering choice of mode
- Minimize requests for sensitive info
- Show similarity to other things one does

Increase Benefits

- Tell how results will be used
- Ask for help
- Ask interesting questions
- Stress that opportunities are limited
- Convey that others have responded
- Provide an advance incentive
- Do not deny benefits
- Use a legitimate and trusted sponsor

Establish Trust

- Show authenticity and legitimacy of request
- Sponsorship by legitimate authority
- Build on past relationships and friendships
- Provide a token of appreciation in advance
- Assure confidentiality and data protection
- Use professional design



Example: WSU Doctoral Student Experience Survey

- The study was targeted toward students who had successfully completed their required preliminary examinations and had only to finish the dissertation in order to meet their degree requirements.
- Data collection needed to be completed within about a month.



Example: WSU Doctoral Student Experience Survey

- Target Population
 - WSU Graduate Students working on their dissertations
- Topic
 - Experience with Doctoral Program and Dissertation Process.
- Sample Frame
 - Contact Information: Names, addresses, and emails provided by the university registrar
- Timeline
 - One Month
- Budget
 - Interviewers were unaffordable



Example: WSU Doctoral Student Experience Survey

- Day 1: Send a postal letter asking students to respond over the web. Enclose a \$2 incentive with this request.
- Day 4: Send an e-mail that builds upon the information contained in the invitation letter, while emphasizing that the sender is following up by e-mail to provide an electronic link to the survey with the hope that this will make responding easier.
- Day 10: Send a second e-mail request.
- Day 18: Send a postal letter offering the option of responding via mail. Include a paper questionnaire and an addressed and stamped return envelope.
- Day 22: Send a final e-mail follow-up.



Initial communications

Initial communications
sent to students asked to
complete the WSU
Doctoral Student
Experience Survey
(inside addresses have
been altered)

March 29, 2013

Jane Doe
123 Cougar Road
Pullman, WA 99163

Dear Jane,

I am writing to ask for your help with an important survey we are conducting of WSU doctoral students. I understand that you have successfully completed your preliminary examinations and are now at the stage of needing to complete a dissertation.

My colleague, Morgan Millar, and I have been working with the National Science Foundation to better understand how the needs of doctoral training in the U.S. are changing. We are hoping you could spend a few minutes sharing some of your experiences in your doctoral program. In particular, we are interested in factors that may affect bringing the dissertation writing process to a successful conclusion.

To this end, we would greatly appreciate if you would answer a few questions for us. To do so, simply go to this website: www.opinion.wsu.edu/phdexperience

In order to begin the survey, you will need to enter this access code: «RESPID».

We think it should only take about ten minutes to complete the questionnaire.

The survey is confidential. Your individual answers will not be linked with your name or department in any reports of the data. Your participation is voluntary and if you come to any question you prefer not to answer, you are welcomed to skip it and go on to the next. Should you have any questions or comments, please contact me (dillman@wsu.edu) or Thom Allen, the study director (509) 335-1722 or ted@wsu.edu.

We very much appreciate your help with this study, and a small token of appreciation is enclosed with this letter as way of saying thank you.

Many Thanks,



Don A. Dillman
Regents Professor and Deputy Director
Social and Economic Sciences Research Center
Washington State University



Second contact: E-mail

From: Don Dillman [don.dillman@wsu.edu]
Sent: Monday, April 1, 2013 2:00 PM
To: Jane Doe [jane.doe23@wsu.edu]
Subject: WSU Doctoral Student Survey

Dear Jane,

Earlier this week we sent you a letter asking for your help with an important survey. We are conducting this study of WSU doctoral students to learn more about the processes they go through to complete their dissertations and finish their degrees.

I am following up with this e-mail to provide you with an electronic link to the survey website. I hope this link makes it easier for you to respond. It should only take a few minutes to complete the questionnaire.

Simply click on this link and you will automatically be logged into the survey:

<http://www.opinion.wsu.edu/phdexperience>

And enter your personal Access Code in the space provided: <<RESPID>>

The results of this study will help us better understand the needs and experiences of students as they work on their dissertation research. Your participation is very important, and we appreciate you considering our request.

Sincerely,

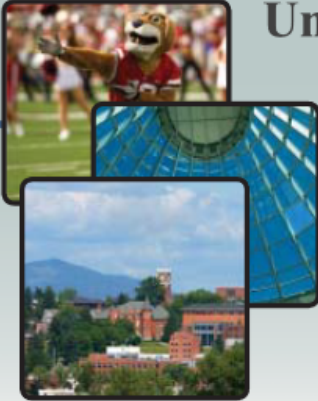


Don A. Dillman
Regents' Professor and Deputy Director
Social and Economic Sciences Research Center



The initial page of the paper questionnaire

- localized identity
- Short questionnaire



Understanding the Doctoral Experience at WSU

Thank you for completing this questionnaire. This study will help us better understand the process students go through during the final stages of their doctoral education. As doctoral training in the United States continues to evolve, it is important that we learn more about students' perspectives and identify any obstacles that may stand in the way of successfully completing one's dissertation.

Your participation is voluntary and your responses will be kept confidential. No personally identifiable information will be associated with your responses in any reports of the data. If you have any questions please feel free to contact Thom Allen, the study director, by email at ted@wsu.edu or by phone at (509) 335-1722.

Q1. In what year did you officially complete your preliminary examinations?

YYYY

Q2. Have you already selected a specific dissertation topic?

☐ No → Skip to Q21 on page 5

☐ Yes

Q3. If yes, which of the following best describes your current status in the dissertation process?

☐ Have not yet begun any research or writing for your dissertation → Skip to Q21 on page 5

☐ Working on a dissertation proposal

☐ Have completed a dissertation proposal

☐ Are in the early stages of research/writing for your dissertation

☐ Are about halfway completed with the research/writing for your dissertation

☐ Are mostly completed with the research/writing for your dissertation

☐ Have fully completed your dissertation

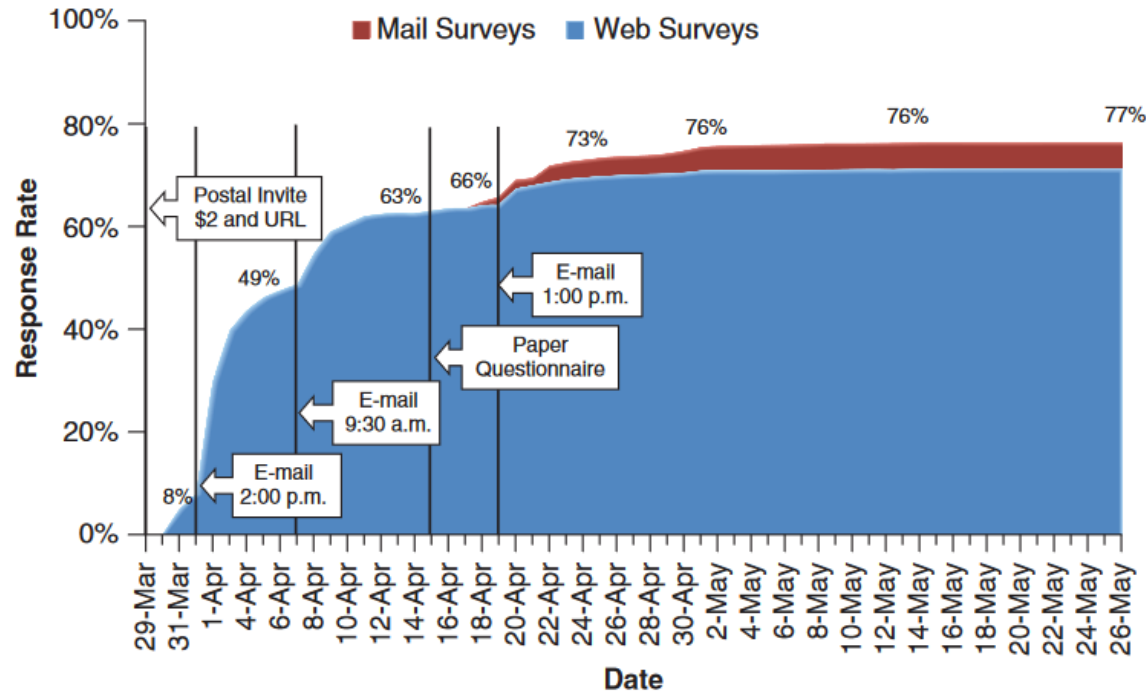
Q4a. Please write the name of the primary field of your dissertation research.

Name of primary field

Now, choose the code from the list on pages 10-11 that best describes the primary field of your dissertation research.

Number of primary field

Example: WSU Doctoral Student Experience Survey



Source: Adapted from *Determining Whether Research Is Interdisciplinary: An Analysis of New Indicators* (Technical Report 13-049), by M. M. Millar, 2013, Pullman: Washington State University, Social and Economic Sciences Research Center.



Methods Used to Decrease Costs

- E-mail provided link to make web response easy
- Paper alternative offered for those opposed to responding by web
- Stamped return envelope provided
- Limited questionnaire length
- Avoided giving choice of modes and instead offered them sequentially

Methods Used to Increase Benefits

- Used legit and trusted sponsor
- Results to improve graduate education
- \$2 prepaid incentive
- Varied message in contacts
- Attractive paper alternative eventually offered
- Title appealed to local identity
- Interest-getting questions were asked early in the questionnaire

Methods Used to Build Trust

- Washington State University sponsorship
- University stationary with contact information was used
- \$2 incentive was provided to everyone upfront
- Communications emphasized efforts to make responding convenient